GinCol Lab · Aula

Student worksheet

Spanish Language and Literature I · 1st year of Bachillerato · How we understand each other · Class 3 of 7 · With Vera

Lab: how do we ask for things?

Class video: https://youtu.be/YTXFaU8F6nY

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

The class is about Spanish, so the examples stay in Spanish, with their meaning in English in brackets.

Before you start: your bet

Think about how you ask for things: the charger, from your brother; a big favour, from someone you don't know; one more day to hand something in, from a teacher. **When what you ask for weighs more, what do you think we do?** Tick one and explain why in one sentence.

1. Switch to a hint.

2. Use a formula, like «¿podría...?» ("could you...?", formal).

3. Ask the same way, but wrap the request up more.

At the end of the class. Did you get it right? Which piece of data made you change your mind, or confirmed it?

While you watch the video

1. What is an indirect speech act? Answer before Vera says it.

2. Three real requests, recorded from university students aged 18 to 23. Which step is each one on: direct, conventional or hint?

3. A girl who wants to make videos, to the other two: «Dadme ideas de vídeos» ("Give me ideas for videos").

4. A boy, to the girl he is cooking with: «¿Me traes la bandejita?» ("Will you bring me the little tray?").

5. A girl whose hair another girl is doing for carnival: «¡Ay! Me está doliendo el pelo. ¿Hay algo que me estés tirando?» ("Ow! My hair is hurting. Is there something you're pulling?").

6. A 26-year-old researcher interviews a 70-year-old woman. At the start she asks her «Cuénteme lo que hacía antes y lo que hace ahora» ("Tell me what you used to do and what you do now"); at the end, «¿Me va a permitir que le haga un cuestionario?» ("Will you allow me to give you a questionnaire?"). What changes between the two requests and what stays the same? Why does that make them an experiment?

7. Another researcher, aged 23, to an 89-year-old man, to give him the questionnaire. Underline the softeners and say which step the request is on:

«Mire, si le parece, vamos a... Porque llevamos, quiera que no... ¿Qué? ¿Hora y media? Y le tengo que hacer unas preguntas. Esto es bastante más aburrido, pero si por el camino se acuerda de otra cosa, usted cuéntemelo» ("Look, if that's all right with you, let's... Because we've been going, like it or not... What? An hour and a half? And I have to ask you a few questions. This is a lot more boring, but if along the way you remember something else, you tell me about it"). 1. Why is it more solid to compare each person with

themselves (in 21 of 28 interviews, the questionnaire carries more softeners) than to compare only everyone's averages? 1. Does the study of the neighbours and the friend prove that closeness matters? Why? 1. Write down one thing the class cannot conclude, and how you could check it yourself.

The requests in questions 2, 3 and 4 are real, from the ESLORA corpus (Universidade de Santiago de Compostela, http://eslora.usc.es; SCOM_C_32, SCOM_C_10, SCOM_C_08, SCOM_M31_037 and SCOM_H31_042; simplified transcription), under a CC BY-NC 4.0 licence. The English glosses are ours.

Do it yourself: ten of your own requests

Find ten requests that you sent yourself, never other people's messages. Don't copy names: write "my brother", "a teacher", "a classmate". For the step, 1 is direct, 2 conventional and 3 a hint. For the softeners, copy them exactly: «por favor» ("please"), «un momento» ("just a moment"), a reason, a diminutive…

	Who to, and how close you are	Are they in charge of you?	How much you were asking for	Step (1, 2, 3)	Softeners
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					

Then, look at your table.

1. Does the hypothesis hold: the more you ask for, and the less close you are to someone, the more you beat about the bush?

2. And our correction: the more you ask for, the more softeners, without going up a step?

3. Can you find a counterexample? Say what you were asking for, who to, and why you think it doesn't hold.

4. What can't you conclude from ten of your own requests?

5. If you speak another language (català or valencià, galego, euskara, English…), write how you would make one of your requests in it. Do you ask in the same way?

Practice

1. Order these from most direct to most roundabout, and give the step of each: «¿Me pasas la sal?» ("Will you pass me the salt?"), «Pásame la sal» ("Pass me the salt") and «Esto está un poco soso, ¿no?» ("This is a bit bland, isn't it?"). What does the listener have to infer from the last one?

2. Count the softeners in this real request, made by an interviewer to an 83-year-old man in Medina-Sidonia (Cádiz): «Quería preguntarle si le importa que le saque una foto, aparte de lo que le hemos grabado, una fotito. [RISAS] Yo se la mando luego…» ("I wanted to ask you if you'd mind me taking a photo of you, apart from what we've recorded, a little photo. [LAUGHTER] I'll send it to you later…").

3. Write how you would ask for one more day to hand in a piece of work: once, to your teacher; another time, to your classmate in your group. Explain each difference with the three things that weigh: distance, power and what you are asking for.

The request in exercise 2 is real, from COSER (I. Fernández-Ordóñez, dir., *Corpus Oral y Sonoro del Español Rural*, ; San José de Malcocinado, Medina-Sidonia, Cádiz, COSER-1116-01, 2012), under a CC BY-NC-ND 4.0 licence: it is reproduced word for word, and the English gloss in brackets is ours, only to help with reading. The other examples are invented.

Keep thinking

Can you be polite to a voice assistant? In 2018, Amazon and Google added an option to theirs, designed for children, that says thank you when you say please. Does it make sense to say «por favor» ("please") to a machine? Write down your position and the best reason for the opposite one.

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